LA CUCINA ITALIANA - SEMPLICE ITALIAN KITCHEN | BUDGET-FRIENDLY ITALIAN

What to Do with Leftover Italian Bread: Tuscan Panzanella, Bruschetta & Crispy Pangrattato

Never waste a loaf! Discover what to do with leftover Italian bread-including 20-minute Tuscan Panzanella, Pappa al Pomodoro, Bruschetta, and Pangrattato (+ PDF).

Prep: 10 mins | Cook: 10 mins | Total: 20 mins | Yield: 4 servings | Calories: 330 kcal

INGREDIENTS CHECKLIST

[ ] 350g (about 6 thick slices) Day-Old or Stale Italian Country Loaf (torn into rustic chunks or slices)
[ ] 400g Ripe Heirloom or Plum Tomatoes (chopped with all their juices)
[ ] 4 tbsp olive oil, 1.5 tbsp vinegar Extra Virgin Olive Oil & Red Wine Vinegar
[ ] 2 cloves garlic, 1 bunch basil Fresh Garlic Cloves & Sweet Basil Leaves
[ ] 150g Optional Creamy Burrata or Fior di Latte (torn over the warm bread)

STEP-BY-STEP CULINARY INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Toast or Char the Stale Italian Bread [8 mins]

Tear or slice your leftover Italian bread and toast in a 400F (200C) oven or cast-iron skillet with 1 tablespoon of olive oil for 8 minutes until golden and crisp outside.

Step 2: Macerate Tomatoes in Vinegar & Olive Oil [10 mins]

In a large bowl, toss chopped ripe tomatoes with flaky sea salt, red wine vinegar, crushed garlic, and 3 tablespoons of extra virgin olive oil for 10 minutes to draw out a savory dressing.

Step 3: Toss for Panzanella or Top for Bruschetta [2 mins]

Toss the toasted bread cubes directly into the tomato juices for 5 minutes so the bread rehydrates into a chewy Tuscan Panzanella (or spoon over whole grilled slices with burrata).

Step 4: Bonus: Save Crumbs for Crispy Pangrattato

Pulse any remaining bread heels into coarse crumbs and fry in garlic olive oil until golden to sprinkle over pasta as "Poor Man’s Parmesan."

CHEF’S PRO TIPS & STORAGE

* Stale bread works 10x better than fresh soft bread for Panzanella and Pappa al Pomodoro because dried-out starch absorbs tomato juice and olive oil without turning mushy.
* Keep a jar of homemade toasted garlic Pangrattato in the fridge for up to 2 weeks to add instant crunch to any pasta dish.